

Why are some babies born prematurely? There are certain factors that can increase your risk of going into preterm labor, but the truth is the exact cause of preterm birth is not known. Some lifestyle factors, such as cigarette smoking, are strongly associated with preterm delivery. Twin pregnancy or a prenatal infection can also increase the risk of preterm labor. Some people may need to deliver early due to complications such as preeclampsia or diabetes, or if the baby is not growing well enough due to poor placental function. Having a previous baby who was born preterm also increases the likelihood of having another baby born prematurely.

KANGAROO CARE

If your premature baby goes into a Neonatal Intensive Care Unit (NICU) you may be able to take care of him using a method called kangaroo care. You will be asked to hold your baby on your chest between your breasts with his head turned so that his ear is next to your heart.

Developed in Bogota, Columbia, in response to a lack of incubators, kangaroo care is shown to have many benefits for NICU babies—mainly that their heart and breathing rates regularize quite quickly, allowing them to sleep for much longer periods. The baby's temperature is regulated by the temperature fluctuations in your breasts, meaning he doesn't have to expend energy keeping himself warm.

This, in addition to the extra sleep, preserves his energy for other vital functions, such as brain development and weight gain. Breast-feeding is also more successful and some kangarooed babies lose none of their birth weight.